

Main

Report Name (Org_Country_Year_Report Type)

EPL_Ghana_2022-23_3-month report

Fellowship Organization

Emerging Public Leaders (EPL)

Fellowship City

Accra

Fellowship Country

Ghana

Fellowship Start Date

07/12/2022

Anticipated Fellowship End Date

07/14/2022

What is your fellowship title/role?

Princeton in Africa Fellow

What are your primary responsibilities?

- Research and develop grant proposals for foundations, government agencies, and corporate philanthropies, ensuring that requirements are met
- Research and analyze new funding opportunities and present findings to Country Director
- Create graphics and content for EPL Social Media Platforms regarding the Ghana country program
- Coordinate with EPL Global, Kenya, and Liberia Country Program to create social media content highlighting each countries programs

I receive adequate direction and support to perform my fellowship responsibilities.

Neutral

Did you receive any sort of orientation, handover or onboarding when you started your fellowship?

Yes

Please describe your orientation/onboarding and note who handled it.

After arriving to Ghana, I almost immediately went on a staff retreat with EPL. This is where I got an idea of what I would be doing. I also got some valuable tips and advice from the previous PiAf fellow who also attended the retreat.

I also received some onboarding from EPL Global Program Associate regarding comms work I would be doing.

If you did not receive any kind of orientation, what information or guidance were you provided at the start of your fellowship?**Describe a representative day at work.**

I have two mandatory in office days Monday and Thursday. On Monday's we have a check in meeting between 10:00 am -11:30 am and on Thursday's we have a brainstorming meeting between 10:00am -12:00 pm. After the meetings we work in office until about 5:30pm. Tuesday, Wednesdays, and Fridays are flex work days where you can work from home. I usually alternate working from home and coming into the office weekly on those days.

On average, how many hours per week do you work?

40

How would you describe your effectiveness in your fellowship post so far?

Neutral

Please briefly describe 1-2 specific projects that you have undertaken or accomplishments you have made so far.

A major project I worked on and coordinated was our International Youth Day 2022 Panel. This panel included members from the Ghana, Liberia, and Kenya country programs, with people joining from all three countries. It was a great virtual panel and a specific project I am extremely proud of.

What is your organization's work culture like?**What is your office environment like? Please comment on the size and structure of the office(s) where you do most of your work.**

In our office I work at a co working table in the main room. I work in the room with 4 of my colleagues. We are a small team of seven for now for future hires coming within the next months.

To whom do you report?

My supervisor in country is the Ghana Country Director.

My supervisor for EPL Global is the Programs Associate.

Have you had an initial check-in with your supervisor to set up a work plan and to set goals for your work during your fellowship year?

Yes

Was this meeting helpful in understanding your role and setting goals for your fellowship year?

Yes this meeting was helpful. Since my roles and focuses changed from what originally I was told, this allowed me to get more direction under my new supervisor.

Please explain why you have not met with your supervisor and if you have plans to do so going forward.

Please briefly indicate 3-5 professional goals you have for the rest of your fellowship year. Your professional goals should align with your work plan.

My main goal is to learn more about grant writing and fundraising. Since I have no prior experience in this. I want to make sure I am able to contribute to EPL in a meaningful way and secure potential funding for the organization.

Another goal is to use my communications skills to create one pagers and graphics to use when submitting funding request.

Another goal is create in country resources and SOP for grant writing and funding so there can be resources for this position if they hire a professional for the role.

How often do you check in with your supervisor?

Weekly

Have you had an opportunity to travel for work so far?

No

Describe this travel opportunity. Include location(s) and a brief description of the purpose of the trip(s).

I feel adequately prepared for my position's professional responsibilities.

Neutral

Please briefly explain your response.

I don't feel adequately prepared with my previous experience for part of my professional responsibilities with EPL. Though I have found that my English and writing background has significantly helped me in being able to write and compose compelling language about EPL. I am worried about not being able to secure any funding for EPL this year. However, I intend to take the proper steps to hopefully secure funding for elements of the fellowship program or start initial relationships that can turn into funds later for EPL.

Life at Fellowship Site

How did you travel to your host country and site? Please be specific

I purchased my ticket directly through Delta Airlines. Due to the raise in flight prices and the start date with EPL, I flew during a peak time which reflects in my flight price. I flew with delta Airlines from DCA to JFK with a layover then JFK to Accra. I also booked a return flight for next July to return through those same cities. The roundtrip ticket including fee for extra baggage was \$2,811.17 USD. EPL covered \$1,200 of my flight. I paid for my flight via credit card because I could not afford to pay for it out right. Making payments towards my flight is difficult with my stipend. I advise possibly raising money towards your flight depending on your financial situation as this has been my biggest hardship being a PiAf fellow.

What kind of visa/ permit do you have or applied for?

I already had a Visa for Ghana in my passport, however when I arrived it was not honored so I had to get a Visa on Arrival in the Airport which cost \$125. EPL reimbursed me for this cost.

How did you obtain (or are obtaining) your visa or permit?

Visa on Arrival at the Airport. I also needed a residency and work permit in Ghana. I started that process after arriving in Ghana. EPL covered that cost.

Did you apply for and receive your visa / permit before heading to your host country or after arriving?

After Arriving

What costs were associated with obtaining your visa or permit?

\$125 for the Visa

Did you pay the visa / permit costs or were they covered by your organization?

I payed out of pocket and then got reimbursed by EPL

Are you still having challenges obtaining your visa/ permit?

No

If yes, please explain further

g) Do you have any suggestions to help future Fellows navigate the visa / permit application process?

Please start the visa process early just in case you need help navigating from PiAf or your host organization

What vaccinations were you required to obtain prior to your departure? How much did your vaccinations cost? Did you get a yellow fever vaccination?

I spent \$475.00 on vaccines. I received typhoid, hep A booster, polio and Meningococcal

How was your arrival and first week in your host country? Any improvements that could streamline the assimilation process for future Fellows?

I arrived in country and immediately the next day I was on the road to a staff retreat for the whole day. I didn't have much time to rest or adjust so I felt very tired and sluggish the entire weekend. I pushed through and enjoyed the retreat with my colleagues. I think giving the fellow at least 2-3 days to settle in and recover from the journey could help the assimilation process better.

Is housing provided by and/or paid for by your organization? Please explain.

My housing is paid for by my host organization. I am paying for my own utilities that includes electricity, water, and garbage.

Do you live in a location that is more urban or rural?

Somewhat Urban (Suburban)

Please describe your living environment

I live in an apartment building which is located near AnC Mall so I have access to grocery stores and grocery marts. It also has restaurants near by and my office is near by.

How do you typically travel between your home and your work? How much does your daily transportation cost and how long is your commute?

I walk about 20 minutes to work everyday. If it is not dark outside, I also walk home from work.

If you live in a more rural area, what are the closest urban areas you can travel to for shopping, airport, larger medical centers, etc.?

I live in a suburb of the main city called East Legon. While living here is convenient for work. I am anywhere between 30 minutes to an hour from Accra central which is where a lot of things happen and are located. Specifically in the weekends I spend a significant amount of money going to things in Accra Central.

How is the weather in your host country? What season are you presently in?

The weather in Ghana is hot with a side of humid. Currently, we are transitioning from rainy to non rainy season. Rainy season was still significantly hot to me even though it rained a lot.

What is the appropriate clothing for work and outside of work at your fellowship post and in your community in general?

I wear business casual to work. Outside of work I wear a lot of breathable dresses, short sleeves, and shorts because of the heat. However at night I try to cover up even though I am very hot because of the vicious mosquitos.

How have you been spending your free time?

I spend my time relaxing, going to coffee shops, trying new restaurants, and reading. I have found it hard to engage in nightlife here on the weekends mostly because its not the safest to do alone. When the other fellow in Ghana is in town, we try to get together and do things. In my experience it is hard to engage in socializing here alone. I have attended a play and the movies since I have been here.

I've been able to successfully navigate my personal/social life both back at home and at my fellowship post.

Strongly Disagree

Please briefly explain your response below.

I feel like my social life at my fellowship post has been lacking so far. I have tried to incorporate more things so I don't feel isolated and alone. I definitely think it would be better to have multiple fellows in Accra to really be able to enjoy.

Would you say you live and work in a safe area?

I would say I live and work in relatively safe areas. Crimes do happen in my area of residency mainly robbery.

What precautions do you take to ensure your safety?

I do not walk or go out at night alone. If I am out to dinner or coming back late I stay vigilant of my surroundings and try to stay in heavily populated areas.

What has been your experience with crime so far? (Please note that any security or safety concerns or incidents should be reported directly to PiAf staff per PiAf safety and security protocol.)

I have seen the aftermath of crime that has happen to people or have heard instances of crime.

Describe the incidence of crime and the general security situation within your city/town. Could you recommend specific areas future Fellows might consider for safe housing? What about areas that should be avoided?

I would consider communities like East Legon safe for housing purposes. Most apartments or places have security or at least a watchman. I recommend staying in a place that has a security gate or post.

Please refer back to the goals you set for yourself before orientation. Are you working towards these goals? Have you met any of them? Changed any of them? Please explain.

The goals I set for myself before orientation was to be present, adaptable and impactful in my work. I think that I am continuing to work towards these goals everyday. I think I am meeting the preset and adaptable goals well in everyday life and work. I don't think I am being impactful in my work just yet but as I continue to get my footing and learn more about grant writing and funding coordination, I hope that will change.

Do you have any frustrations with your living arrangements, your work or your life outside of work?

I had a good bit of frustrations initially with living arrangements, what I expected to be working on vs. what I am actually working on, and some aspects of life outside of work. In my first three months I felt unsettled and found it hard to get my footing. Once I was settled into my permanent accommodation, I started to feel more at ease with everyday life.

Has there been anything that you have needed but have not been able to locate or acquire?

Most of the things I have found it hard to acquire is related to food and dietary restrictions. Having a peanut allergy has been hard because it is hard to locate and acquire things that are peanut free. Many of the local foods here have peanut in them and many products include peanut traces. If you have a particular allergy especially nut related you have to be particularly vigilant about what you buy and eat. Since I gave up red meat years ago, it has also been hard for me to acquire affordable meat alternatives like turkey and fish.

How have you dealt with "culture shock"?

I have dealt with culture shock since arriving in Ghana. I feel the culture shock hit me the most in instances where I needed to get things accomplished. Systems that were not streamlined or efficient really frustrated me in the beginning.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...surprising?

One of the most surprising things for me is how I am viewed on the continent as a Black woman from America. In many situations I have felt stereotyped, overcharged, and panhandled. I am also often called "white girl and obroni" which translates into white person or foreigner. One of the most surprising things was being in a place where I looked like everybody else but I was still getting pointed out so easily.

What about your experience thus far has been the most...challenging?

The most challenging thing has been budgeting and stretching my stipend in the current economy of Ghana. Inflation in Ghana is at an alarming 40% and Ghana has been ranked by the World Bank with the highest food prices on the continent. The value of the cedi is so depreciated that all business and shop are raising their prices constantly with no regulation. The prices I am currently facing in Ghana are drastically different from what I was paying in Ghana in 2019 when I studied abroad. Since I did not come to the program with a good amount of savings or a financial safety net, I have found it difficult with the current economic trends.

What are the top 3 things you miss the most from your home country or the U.S.?

The top three things I miss most about my home is food, driving/public transit, and amenities.

What are the top 3 things about life in your host country that beat out life in your home country or the U.S.?

The top three things about life in my host country is the cultural expression through the arts, Ghana fabrics and access to getting custom clothes, and the great variety of fresh fruits.

How is your stipend being paid?

My stipend is paid monthly on the last day of the month in U.S. dollars via my U.S. account. If the end of the month falls on the weekend I have to wait for payment until the next business day which is sometimes inconvenient especially if I am at my last.

How are you receiving your stipend funds?

ACH

Did you raise funds to cover part of your fellowship expenses?

I did not raise funds to cover part of my fellowship expenses. My family has pitched in where they are able. I highly recommend raising funds if you don't have means, savings, financial safety net or a high family contribution. PiAf is an investment into your future for both fellow and organization. However, if you come from a low socioeconomic background like myself, some financial parts of the program are a significant financial hardship especially majority of the upfront cost that are associated with preparing to be in country for twelve months.

Please list any additional one-time or infrequent expenses not included in your monthly budget below.

Monthly Budget

Rent	Utilities	Furnishings	Phone	Home Security	Internet
\$700.00	\$100.00	\$50.00	\$100.00	\$0.00	\$65.00
Transportation	Fitness	Entertainment	Groceries	House Cleaning	Eating Out
\$150.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$200.00	\$0.00	\$50.00
Medications	Additional Health Insurance	Travel	Laundry	Other	Total Monthly Budget (Minus Entertainment & Travel)
\$30.00	\$0.00	\$0.00	\$50.00	\$0.00	1495.00
Specify "Other"					

Final Thoughts

PiAf's orientation was sufficient in preparing me to transition into my fellowship.

Agree

Please briefly explain your response about Orientation.

I enjoyed orientation and being able to start building community with our cohort in person. I think it played a major role in how we bonded and support each other through this journey we are all on.

Is there anything in particular that PiAf could cover at orientation that would have better prepared you for your fellowship post? Please specify.

I think a session to prepare us for the inflation and economic situation on the ground would have been helpful and reduced the shock factor and unprepared feeling.

I think a session on beginning a fellowship with a new partner or organization can be very beneficial. Since I am EPL's first fellow that is in country for the full twelve months, I feel there were things that were not fully ready for my arrival. I think a session on navigating the fellowship with a new host organization would be very beneficial in the future.

As we plan the upcoming PiAf Retreat, we hope to incorporate some Fellow suggestions into our programming. What are some topics or sessions you would like to see at the Retreat? (We appreciate your feedback however, we may not be able to accommodate all suggestions or requests this year.)

I think some good programming would be coping mechanisms and tools for coping as we close out the year with our organizations. I think another useful session would be marketing and leveraging our Princeton in Africa experience for jobs and opportunities after our fellowship year.